



TUAREG

CROSSING THE SAHARA DESERT

FACES SWATHED IN INDIGO-DYED SCARVES that are only ever removed in private, the Tuareg are a romantic symbol of the harsh, nomadic desert life. Until the mid-20th century, many still traversed the desert as they had done for centuries, though now most have settled down to work the land. Descended from Arabs and Berbers, the Tuareg were the earliest inhabitants of the Sahara region. They served an important function in the global economy by transporting small, luxury items such as jewelry and weapons from Africa to the markets of the Middle East and Europe. These days, the nomadic lifestyle is dying. Droughts, civil unrest, and the people's minority status in their own countries have compelled many Tuareg to settle, but inevitably it is progress that has dealt nomadism the cruelest blow. The reason the Tuareg no longer command the desert is simply because their camels are no match for the trucks that effortlessly zip back and forth across the Sahara.

